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APPS



Design and development shop the Iconfactory is selling some apps — and AI is partially to blame



At one point, an app called [Twitterrific](#) was one of the most popular iPhone apps for browsing Twitter. These days, the company behind that app, and the many apps that followed, is struggling. And AI may partially be to blame.

On Wednesday, the company known as the Iconfactory admitted it was at a crossroads and was putting up several of its apps for sale due to a lack of resources. While the [announcement](#) positioned the matter as a situation where the Iconfactory's app catalog had simply grown to include too many apps to keep up with and not enough time to do so, the reality is that the business today has no choice but to focus on the apps that offer a better return on investment.

Side products can no longer be maintained, even if they have "loads of happy and loyal customers," says the Iconfactory's co-founder, Ged Maheux, says.

The company says that it will continue to work on apps like [Tapestry](#), [Linea Sketch](#), [Wallaroo](#), and [Tot](#), as well as its new project involving [Retro Pixel Portraits](#), but is accepting "serious offers" for the other apps. These sales will include intellectual property and source code.

Of particular interest is that the company points to AI significantly affecting its business as the reason.

"ChatGPT and other AI services are basically killing @Iconfactory, and I'm not exaggerating or being hyperbolic," Iconfactory developer Sean Heber [said in a Mastodon](#) post earlier this month.

The issue isn't that people are using AI instead of mobile apps, but how vibe coding is affecting the need for app design firms like theirs. Besides building its own apps, the Iconfactory generated revenue by offering app [design services](#), which include things like icon design (hence the name), app design, marketing asset creation, plus branding and consulting services.

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These services helped fuel the business that's now being destroyed by AI. "I know nothing I say is going to get anyone to stop using ChatGPT and generating a new app icon in 5 minutes for the app that you also had ChatGPT write for you in a few hours, but I'm not sure what the rest of us are supposed to do about making enough money to, ya know, live," Heber wrote.

Another issue for the longtime app makers at the Iconfactory was the shutdown of its most popular app, Twitterrific, which was killed by Elon Musk in 2023 when the company (now known as X) [officially banned all third-party clients](#). The move put [Twitterrific](#), [Tweetbot](#), and other apps almost instantly out of business, leading the Iconfactory to [plead with its users to decline their App Store refunds](#) to help them stay afloat.

That, too, has affected the Iconfactory's future, Heber admitted in his posts.

"First Twitter/Elon killed our main app revenue that kept the lights on around here, then generative AI exploded to land a final blow to design revenue," he wrote. "I think perhaps because @Iconfactory design is quite good people have this impression that we're sitting here on a pile of money or something and some huge powerhouse — nope. We've been barely making it since Elon/Twitter. There's only 6 of us and there's no war chest."

After shutting down Twitterrific, the Iconfactory turned to the open social web as a way to generate a new revenue stream. It [launched an app called Tapestry](#), which allows users to

track sources across the open web, including RSS feeds, YouTube, Bluesky, podcasts, Mastodon, Reddit, Tumblr, Micro.blog, and others. The app [offers a variety of clever tools](#) for organizing sources, making feeds, muting and hiding content you don't want to see, and more. It also offered a way for third-party developers to extend Tapestry with add-ons called Connectors, allowing users to add even more open feeds.

That app will remain a part of the company's efforts for now — a Mac app is in the works — but even its future could be uncertain. For one thing, open social media platforms like Mastodon and Bluesky are still dwarfed by tech giants, which means consumer demand for something like Tapestry is fairly niche.

As Heber [shared](#), the app's Kickstarter was a bit of a “Hail Mary” on the company's part, but people aren't subscribing in great enough numbers to make up for the revenue that Twitterrific once brought in, he said.

If AI continues to commoditize the business of app making, the Iconfactory won't be alone in suffering the consequences. But vibe-coded apps aren't necessarily what consumers need, not only because of the lack of human input, but also the [lax security](#) some of these apps offer.

Reached for comment, Maheux agreed that AI had “definitely put a damper on the design side of our services,” though it hasn't “killed” the company yet.

“Many indie developers have adopted AI for an inexpensive or free solution for graphical work like app icons, which has been a core part of the services we offer. We still do, of course, but the frequency of developers coming to us for these services has declined greatly in the last few years,” he told TechCrunch via email.

He also cited other factors impacting the business, like Apple's graphical system, SF Symbols, that developers can use instead. Consumers are tiring of subscriptions for everything. Plus, he points out that the cost of everything has increased over the years, while the cost of apps has not, making it harder to make a living as a small business developer.

“We’ve had to expand our offerings into other areas like UX consulting, coding consultation, and side revenue services to try and make up the revenue from this lost design work. Apple’s introduction of Liquid Glass has offered some new opportunities for design work and consultation, and we’ve been working with a handful of companies on this, so that’s been hopeful,” he noted.

Updated after publication with company comment.

Topics: [AI](#) [Apps](#) [design](#) [developers](#) [iconfactory](#) [iOS apps](#)



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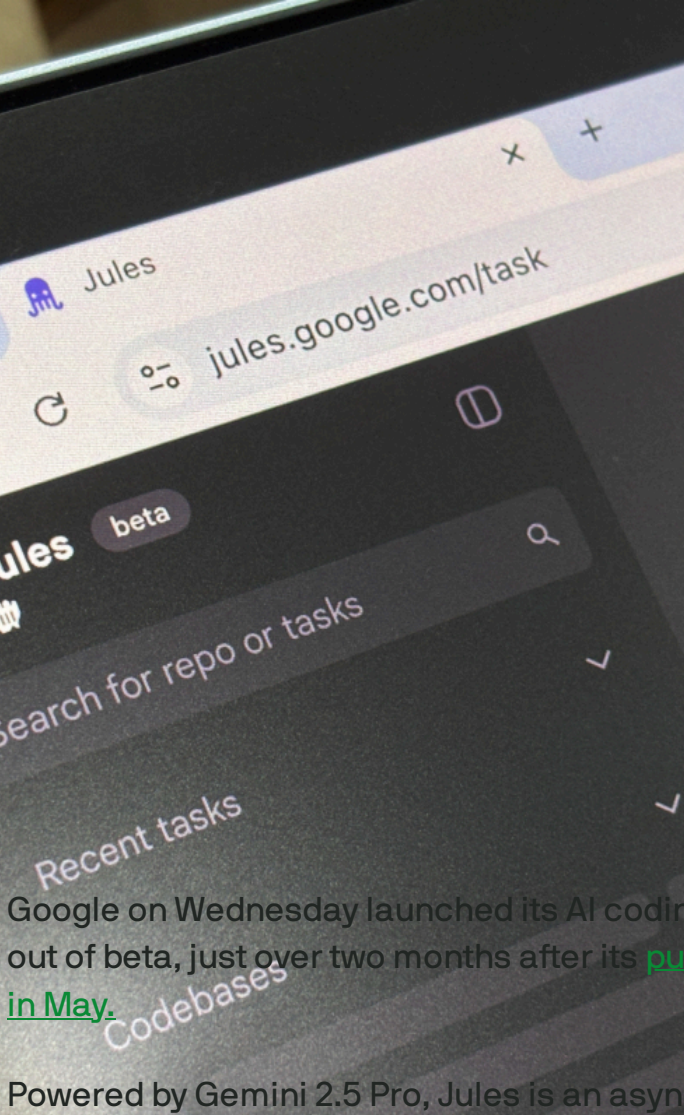
Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [b](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at...

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Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

"The trajectory of where we're going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul," she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an "introductory access" free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules' paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at

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Korevec noted that Jules' packaging and pricing are based on "real usage" insights gathered over the past couple of months.

"The 60-task cap helped us study how developers use Jules and gave us the information we needed to design the new packaging," she said. "The 15/day is designed to give people a sense of whether Jules will work for them on real project tasks."

Google also updated Jules' privacy policy to be more explicit about how it trains AI. If a repository is public, its data may be used for training, but if it is private, Korevec said that no data is sent.

"We got a little bit of feedback from users that it [the privacy policy] wasn't as clear as we thought it was, and so most of it is just responding to that. We didn't change anything about what we're doing on the training side, but we changed the language," Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution, integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

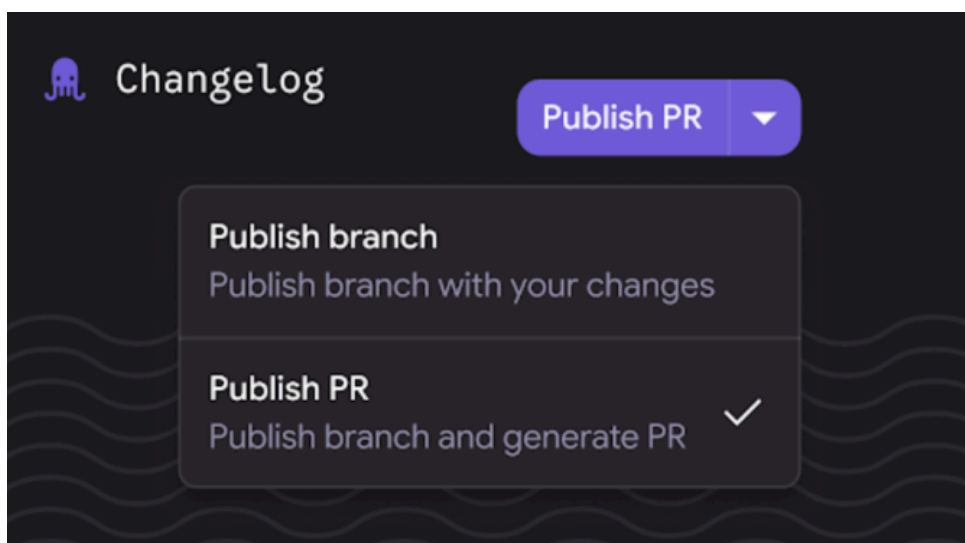


IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

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By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules’ development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules’ user base and its top geographies.

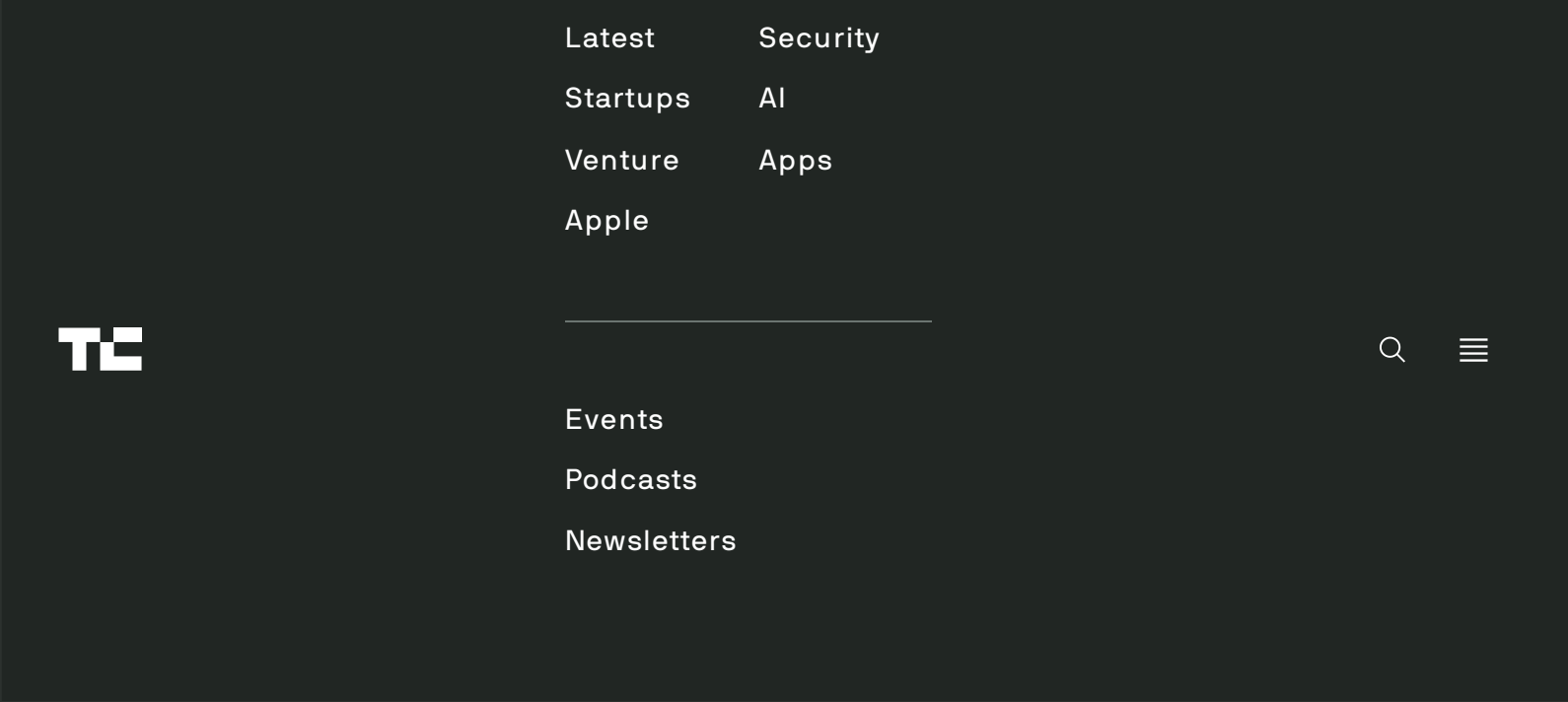
Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs’ team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects internally, and there



Jagmeet Singh
Reporter | X    

Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for TechCrunch. He...

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The backlash against Duolingo going 'AI-first' didn't even matter

Amanda Silberling — 8:32 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Duolingo [announced](#) on Wednesday that it beat its quarterly revenue estimates, even though the company faced widespread backlash for choosing to embrace generative AI over human workers. Duolingo stock rose [almost 30%](#) on the news.

In April, CEO Luis von Ahn [shared](#) that Duolingo would become an "AI-first" company, phasing out its use of contract workers. He also discouraged teams from hiring more employees, unless the team is unable to automate more of its work. With the use of generative AI, Duolingo introduced 148 new language courses, more than doubling its previous offerings.

"Without AI, it would take us decades to scale our content to more learners," von Ahn wrote at the time. "We owe it to our learners to get them this content ASAP."

While some Duolingo users have argued that these AI features are making the app worse, the company's financial metrics tell a different story. Now the company [anticipates](#) making over \$1 billion in revenue this year, and daily active users have grown 40% year-over-year. The growth is significant but falls in the lower range of the company's estimates of growing between 40% and 45%, which an



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investor brought up to von Ahn on Wednesday’s quarterly earnings call.

“The reason we came [in] towards the lower end was because I said some stuff about AI, and I didn’t give enough context. Because of that, we got some backlash on social media,” von Ahn said. “The most important thing is we wanted to make the sentiment on our social media positive. We stopped posting edgy posts and started posting things that would get our sentiment more positive. That has worked.”

On TikTok, the top comments on Duolingo’s videos often remain criticisms of the company’s AI approach. Snarky commenters will ask if videos with multiple people in them are made with AI, to which Duolingo will reply, “Nope. Made by our great team!”

But even if public sentiment toward Duolingo has shifted, its bottom line has not ... and from the company’s perspective, that’s what matters.

Topics: [AI](#) [Apps](#) [duolingo](#)

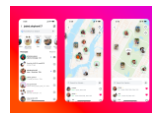


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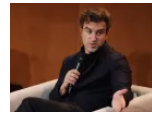
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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also written for...

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AI



First impressions of Alexa+, Amazon's upgraded, AI-powered digital assistant

Sarah Perez — 11:27 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

I owned a lot of Alexa-powered devices in my former home: There were Amazon Echos in most rooms, including an older Echo Plus in the living room, a smattering of Dots, a Spot in a bedroom, and an Echo Show in the kitchen. A Fire TV ran in the bedroom. And, in a drawer, a rarely used Fire HD tablet sat collecting dust.

IMAGE CREDITS: AMAZON

With the [total loss of the home due to a March 2024 house fire](#), there also came a new opportunity: We could now make a fresh start to create a more modernized smart home after rebuilding our house. But whether Alexa still deserves to be the center of our connected home remains to be seen.

To find out whether Alexa is still the best smart assistant for my family, I'm going to test Amazon's AI-powered devices, experiment with AI queries, and write out my thoughts in a multi-part series. With this series, I hope to offer consumers insights as to how well Alexa works in various real-world situations, not company demos.

Alexa needed to catch up



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IMAGE CREDITS: AMAZON

Amazon's assistant, which once gave its users Star Trek vibes as they ordered their home computer to close the blinds or turn off the lights or order milk, no longer seems as revolutionary in the ChatGPT era. Today, people can engage with AI via text and voice chat. Modern AI chatbots and AI-powered services can answer so many more questions, are imaginative, can reason, can create images and art, and generate videos, and with the agentic AI, they can even perform online tasks on your behalf.

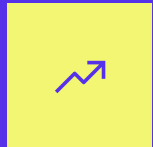
In February 2025, [Amazon announced a complete makeover of its digital voice assistant](#) with the arrival of Alexa+, powered by generative AI. That service began rolling out slowly to customers in March and is now available to “many millions” of users, Amazon says. The system is also model-agnostic, meaning Alexa+ can use whatever she needs in the moment to answer the question or complete the task. Alexa+ is using models from Anthropic and [Amazon Nova](#), among others.

The company teased that this improved Alexa could do more than set timers and alarms, control smart home devices, and answer questions. She leverages generative AI to make sense of information stored in Amazon users' accounts, understand their schedules, and their preferences. She can remember things, process files, and summarize a Ring camera's footage.

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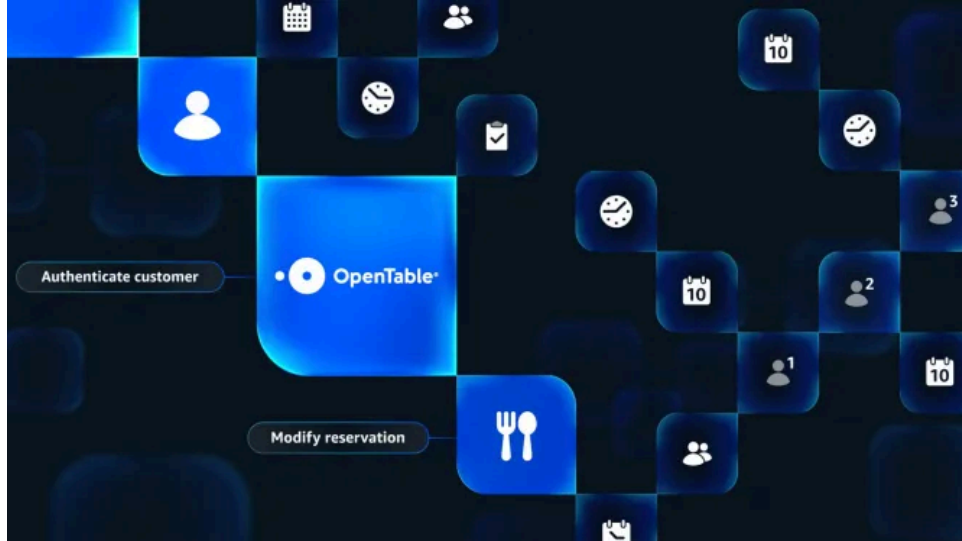


IMAGE CREDITS: AMAZON

Notably, Amazon says it's been working with partners to allow it to take actions for people, like booking dinner reservations or Uber rides, or buying concert tickets. Integrations with Amazon's own grocery service could also have it make shopping lists by speaking to it, and then have those products delivered. Essentially, it's aiming to bring agentic AI into the home.

But before we can get to that, let's see how Alexa+ handles the basics.

In the first part of this series, I'm going to set up Alexa+, use the app, and ask the assistant some questions that only the new Alexa+ can do. Later, I'll test the agentic AI features and smart home integrations.

Setting up Alexa+ on an Echo Spot

Device: Echo Spot

Default music service: Spotify (Premium)

Before moving to my new home, I put Alexa+ to the test on a brand-new Echo Spot after being accepted into the beta. Since I couldn't yet hook up smart home devices in the Airbnb that's served as a temporary residence for over a year, I initially tried to test the device's AI in other ways.

Mainly, I wanted to know if Alexa+ was really all that smart and useful, and if she could do all the things Amazon promised.



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IMAGE CREDITS:TECHCRUNCH

Setting up the Spot was easier than it was with past devices, as now you only need to scan a QR code to get the process started in the Alexa app. The app connected automatically to the home's Wi-Fi; no more weird toggling between the device's network and your own Wi-Fi.

On the next screen, I accepted the invite to upgrade to the new Alexa+ for free, knowing that it's still possible to downgrade to the old Alexa service at any time, if things go wrong.

Onboarding included a short video that explained that Alexa would learn more as I use her, and instructed me on how to talk to Alexa. I then connected my Google account, giving Alexa access to my inbox and calendar.

I ended up on a blank page after doing so, oddly, but after closing the window, the screen informed me that my "Account Linked." (Disclosure: I am running the iOS 26 developer beta on my iPhone, so maybe that's the problem?)

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

On the following screen, I picked the services I wanted to use with Alexa+, which today include OpenTable, Ticketmaster, Uber, and Thumbtack. I checked all the boxes, then moved to the following screen to grant the necessary permissions, one by one.

While it's a bit tedious to do so — and something that could be even more tedious in time as more services are added — I did appreciate that it felt like I was in control of the data sharing and could see exactly what each service was requesting before agreeing.

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

The following screen confirmed that Fodor's travel planning service was already integrated with Alexa+, but it didn't require permissions. It also noted that services like Uber Eats, Grubhub, and Vagaro would be added later on.

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

The Alexa app itself is still sorely lacking in user interface design. Despite many updates, the app still feels somehow both plain and too busy. It lacks color and traditional mobile app navigation patterns, and it tries to cram too many examples of “things to do” on its home screen.

Meanwhile, trying to locate how to do the necessary first steps — like linking my preferred music service — is buried in the interface. Nope, you don’t tap on your profile icon, Settings, and then scroll down to “Preferred service providers.” For some reason, that’s where you set your preferred News, Calendar, and Email providers, but not your preferred Music service.

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

Instead, you tap on the hamburger menu at the bottom of the screen. You then tap on the “Music & More” screen. (What’s the “More”? Podcasts? Audiobooks?)

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

I set Spotify as my default music service, the default choice for artists and genre stations, and the default for podcasts. There was no option to set my default audiobooks service.

In this section, there was also a list of services I had previously linked with Alexa. Here, Amazon's Audible — which I would prefer to set as the default for audiobooks — was listed alongside other streamers, like Pandora, Amazon Music, Apple Music, and others. But when I tapped on Audible, I simply got an error that says “You’ve reached the end of Alexa’s knowledge. Just kidding. This skill no longer exists. [Click here to go back.](#)”

Uh, OK. I mean, would it not make sense to just *remove the broken thing* that no longer exists?

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

In any event, I'm here to try Alexa+, not yell at a poorly designed mobile app.

I'll figure out audiobooks later, I guess.

Note for this series:

In these tests, I may have shared personal information with Alexa that I will not be publishing. In those cases, I will put a description of the item — like “child’s school” — in [brackets]. I have also slightly changed some of the dates, times, and numbers to further obscure any personal information that could be used to develop an understanding of my accounts, meetings, or household routines.

Can Alexa+ manage the family's schedule?

Busy households, especially ones with kids, often use a family calendar to track activities, doctor’s appointments, errands, meetings, classes, and more. Our family calendar is maintained in Google Calendar, accessed on our phones through the native Google Calendar app, and on Mac desktops via the calendar app Fantastical.

Amazon suggests that Alexa+ can help summarize your day, add new events to your calendar, identify conflicts, and more.

In practice, Alexa was fairly adept at letting me inquire about the schedule and various events, but she interrupted me when I was asking to add a new meeting to my calendar. I said, “Can you add a meeting to my calendar on August 6 at 2 p.m. with [entity] about—” Here she cut me off to ask, “What would you like to title this meeting?”

Annoying, but not end-of-the-world terrible, I suppose.

I was more easily able to ask things like “What’s on my calendar today?” and follow up to ask further questions — like if there were any meetings later in the week or to repeat one of the appointments. I didn’t have to say “Alexa” again to continue the conversation. It felt more natural, but there’s a very slight lag with her responses at times.

(As an aside, when I went to find the history of my voice chats for writing this post, I asked Alexa where they could be found. She told me to look in the app’s Settings under the More menu, then look for Alexa Privacy or Review Voice History. She’s wrong. Neither option was there. I did, however, find my history from the “Recent Chats” link on the app’s home screen. Alexa, c’mon! Know thyself.)

Alexa, remember this

Another thing Alexa+ is supposed to be able to do is store information on your behalf. To test this out, I asked her to remember my frequent flier number. This interaction went poorly.

Me: Alexa, can you remember my Delta SkyMiles number?

Alexa: Sure, I’d be happy to remember your Delta SkyMiles number for you. What’s the number?

*Me: *opens mouth to speak**

Alexa: I've added that to Remember This in the Alexa privacy section of the app. Also, keep in mind that anyone who has access to any of your Alexa devices can use their voice to hear its contents.

Um, what? I tried again.

Me: Alexa, can you remember my SkyMiles number?

Alexa: Certainly! I'd be happy to remember your SkyMiles number for you. What's the number? OK, saved it.

She didn't even take a breath!

Curious, I asked her what she thinks the number is. She responded, "I don't have your SkyMiles number saved yet. Would you like to tell me your number now?"

Me: Yes.

Alexa: OK, go ahead and tell me your Delta SkyMiles number.

Me: [says the eight-digit number]

Alexa: OK, saved it.

Me: What's my SkyMiles number?

Alexa: "Six hundred fifty-two million, four hundred eighty-six thousand..."

(Note: I changed the number for the purpose of this post, but yes, Alexa read it out like a long numeral instead of just saying 6-5-2-4-8-6, etc. Not helpful!)

Alexa, read my email

Alexa+ can now supposedly understand documents you upload in the Alexa app or forward to her at alexa@alexa.com using the email address associated with your Amazon account.

To try this, I forwarded an email from my child's school. These come frequently and have a lot of useful information in them,

but are often lost in the inbox. Perhaps if Alexa can handle this task, a new Gmail forwarding filter is in order?

Me: Alexa, summarize the recent email from school.

Alexa: The recent email from [my child's school] is a welcome-back letter for the 2025-2026 school year. It announces an "Early Start Day" orientation on August [date] for new students, with an information session for new parents that evening. Regular classes begin on August [date].

Me: Was there any information specifically for [grade] in that email?

Alexa: I don't see any information specifically for [grade] in that email. The letter mainly covers general school information, orientation dates, and important deadlines for all students.

IMAGE CREDITS: ALEXA APP SCREENSHOT

Great, that worked, it seems. But here's where things got a little trickier.

Me: Are there any important dates I should add to my calendar?

*Alexa: *repeats the important dates from above**

Me: Can you add those to my calendar for me?

Alexa: (Which must have misheard me?) Checking your calendar. Sarah, your calendar is looking busy. You have [activity] ongoing until August 16th, you have [activity]. On Thursday—

Me: (interrupting) I was asking if you could add the dates in the email to my calendar for me?

Alexa: Certainly, I'll do that. (Pause) I've added the following dates to your calendar:

- *Course Correction Request Period from August [date] through August [date]*
- *New Student Orientation Early Start Day on August [date, time]*
- *First Day of School on August [date]*

Is there anything else you'd like me to add?

While this process seems efficient and is certainly helpful in a pinch, you'll notice I left it up to Alexa to determine which dates were “important.” As a result, she picked the three dates closest to today. The email itself, however, contained a list of 12 important school dates, including things like Meet the Teacher Night, Open House, Midyear Graduation, and more.

All of them were formatted the same way in the email under the heading “Important Dates.” Had I only relied on Alexa and had not read the email itself, I would have missed these.

Oh, dear.

Alexa, help me save money

Another Alexa+ promise is that she can help you track prices on Amazon so you can save money when things go on sale. All right, I'll bite! I like online shopping.

I decided to try tracking a couple of things, including one skin care item and a Coach handbag. These are things I definitely don't need, but want — the kinds of things where a discount could prompt a purchase.

AMAZON.COM SCREENSHOT.

Me: Alexa, I want to know when the Glow Recipe Plum Plumping and Hydrating Hyaluronic Acid Skin Care Serum goes on sale.

Alexa: Just a second ... I've set up a deal tracker for the Glow Recipe Plum Plumping Serum. I'll notify you when it goes on sale.

Me: How much is it right now?

*Alexa: *silence**

Me: Did you hear me?

Alexa: Checking on that. Yes, I heard you. I've already set up a deal tracker for the Glow Recipe Plum Plumping Serum. You'll get a notification when it goes on sale.

Me: How much is it now?

*Alexa: *More silence.**

OK, I guess we'll wait on that one.

Next up, I tried the handbag.

Me: Alexa, I want to know when the Coach Swinger handbag goes on sale.

Alexa: Certainly, I'll check that. Got it! I set up a deal tracker for the Coach Swinger handbag. I'll let you know when it goes on sale.

Me: Is it out of stock in blue?

Alexa: **Silence**

Me: *Is the Coach handbag I just asked you about out of stock in blue?* (Note: It was, per Amazon’s website at the time of the request.)

Alexa: *Let me check that for you. (Long pause) I found the Coach Swinger handbag, but it’s currently available in black. The blue option isn’t showing up in the search results, which might mean it’s out of stock. Would you like more details about the available options?*

Me: *No.*

The Coach Swinger handbag in blue does show up on the product page on the web, for what it’s worth; it’s listed as “temporarily out of stock.” The bag is also available in both black and red, but Alexa only mentioned the black option for some reason. Not super helpful.

And we’ll have to wait to see if it ever goes on sale.

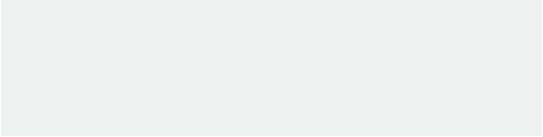
Off to a slow start

With these first introductory tests, Alexa+ seems very much like a beta product. She’s trying but is prone to making mistakes and not being thorough. Sometimes, she doesn’t even seem to hear me or doesn’t know what to do.

Given that many of these are out-of-the-box features that don’t require integrations, you have to wonder how well Alexa+ will do at navigating the web and taking action for you.

In the next installment of this series, I’ll continue testing the AI and will try some of the agentic AI features with Alexa+.

Topics: [AI](#) [Alexa](#) [alexa plus](#) [Amazon](#)



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